‘Please do me a favour,’ I told Dhawan. ‘Order an investigation into the furniture deal. And ensure that the inquiry report is ready in a month; you can’t keep me on tenterhooks any longer.’

Dhawan agreed. To begin the investigation, the first thing needed was the letter Gowarikar had written to Dhawan, and Dhawan had signed, mentioning the furniture deal as the reason for my transfer. Dhawan called Gowarikar on phone, in my presence.

‘Since you have cited a probable corruption in the furniture deal as the reason for Nambi, and now that he is contesting it, it’s only fair that the matter be investigated,’ Dhawan told Gowarikar. ‘And yes, you have to get to the bottom of it in a month.’

On the assurance that the deal would be investigated and a decision taken within a month, I got back to work, in the programme planning and evaluation group.

A month passed by, but nothing happened. I went back to Gowarikar, and again to Dhawan. This time Dhawan had no reason to hesitate. In front of me, Dhawan called Gowarikar on the phone and asked for the paper in which Gowarikar had requested my transfer citing corruption charges. Gowarikar said he had already passed on the paper to David, Dhawan’s personal assistant.

I could not help but say, at this juncture, that he would not have given the paper to David.

‘Are you an astrologer?’ asked Dhawan.

I told him that Gowarikar was trying to shunt me without an inquiry, and hence he would not produce the paper. Dhawan called up David who soon confirmed that Gowarikar had sent no such paper.

Dhawan called Gowarikar again, this time asking him to send a copy from his files. As soon as Dhawan kept the phone down, I told him Gowarikar would not send him a copy. A couple of weeks later, Gowarikar told Dhawan that he was not able to trace the paper and needed more time.

Dhawan lost his cool. He constituted an inquiry committee headed by T N Seshan. The committee found no wrong doing on my part. Dhawan apologized to me. My intention was not to make Dhawan feel bad, but expose Gowarikar.

Having done that, I was about to tell Dhawan that I wanted nothing more and wanted to quit when Dhawan spoke.